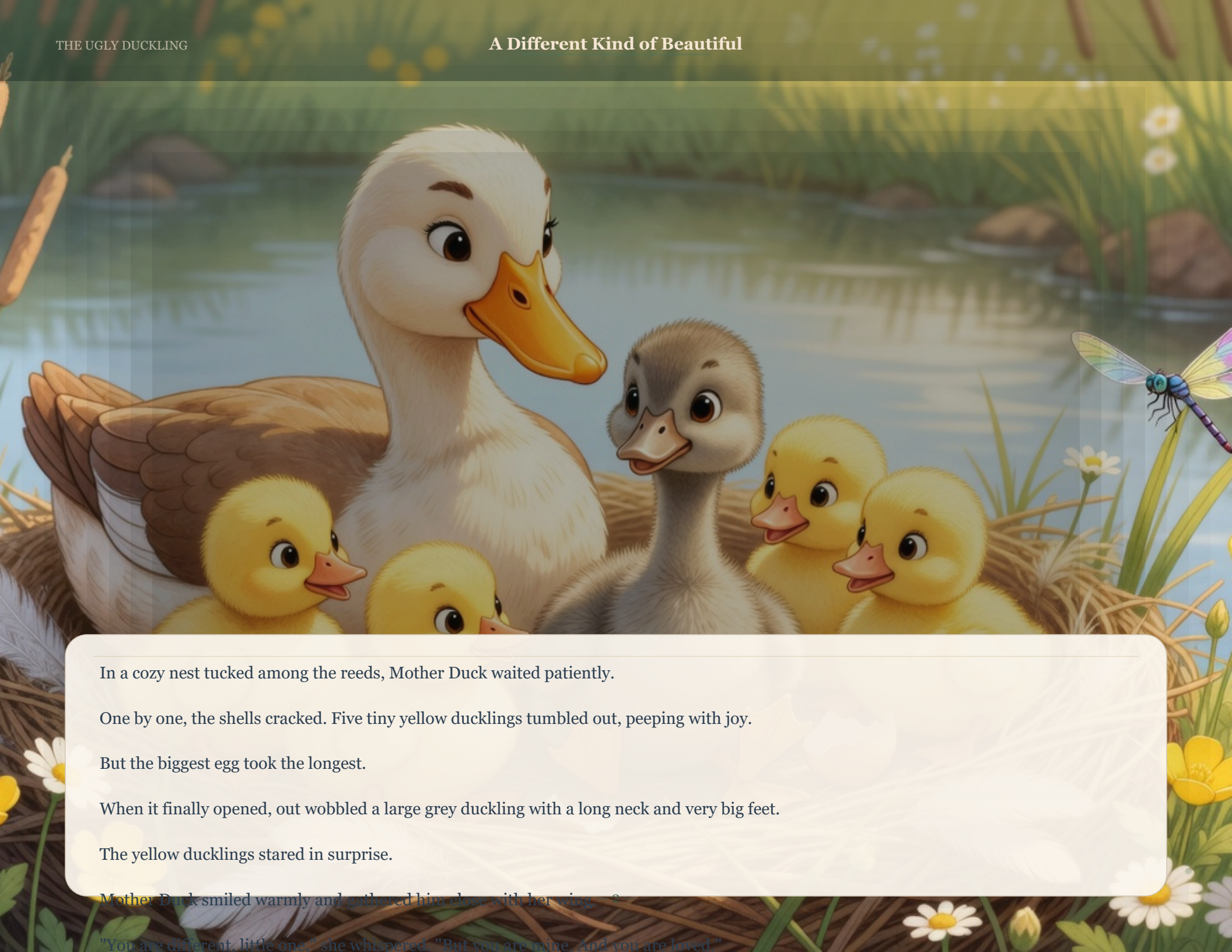


THE UGLY DUCKLING

*A Story About Courage, Kindness,
and Becoming Who You Are Meant to Be*



For every child who has ever felt different



In a cozy nest tucked among the reeds, Mother Duck waited patiently.

One by one, the shells cracked. Five tiny yellow ducklings tumbled out, peeping with joy.

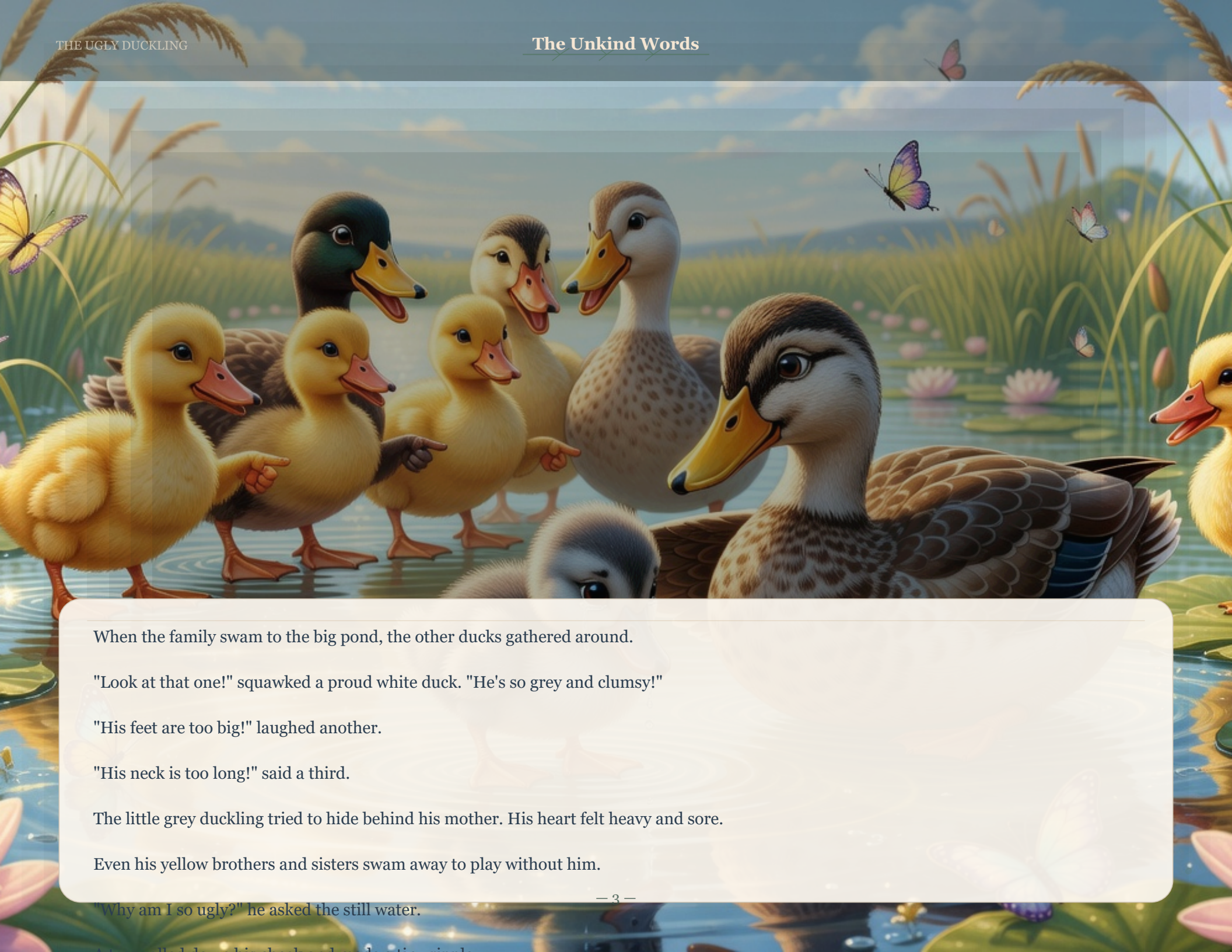
But the biggest egg took the longest.

When it finally opened, out wobbled a large grey duckling with a long neck and very big feet.

The yellow ducklings stared in surprise.

Mother Duck smiled warmly and gathered him close with her wing.

"You are different, little one," she whispered. "But you are mine. And you are loved."



When the family swam to the big pond, the other ducks gathered around.

"Look at that one!" squawked a proud white duck. "He's so grey and clumsy!"

"His feet are too big!" laughed another.

"His neck is too long!" said a third.

The little grey duckling tried to hide behind his mother. His heart felt heavy and sore.

Even his yellow brothers and sisters swam away to play without him.

"Why am I so ugly?" he asked the still water.

The Long Winter

The little duckling could not bear the cruel words any longer.

One foggy morning he slipped away from the only home he knew.

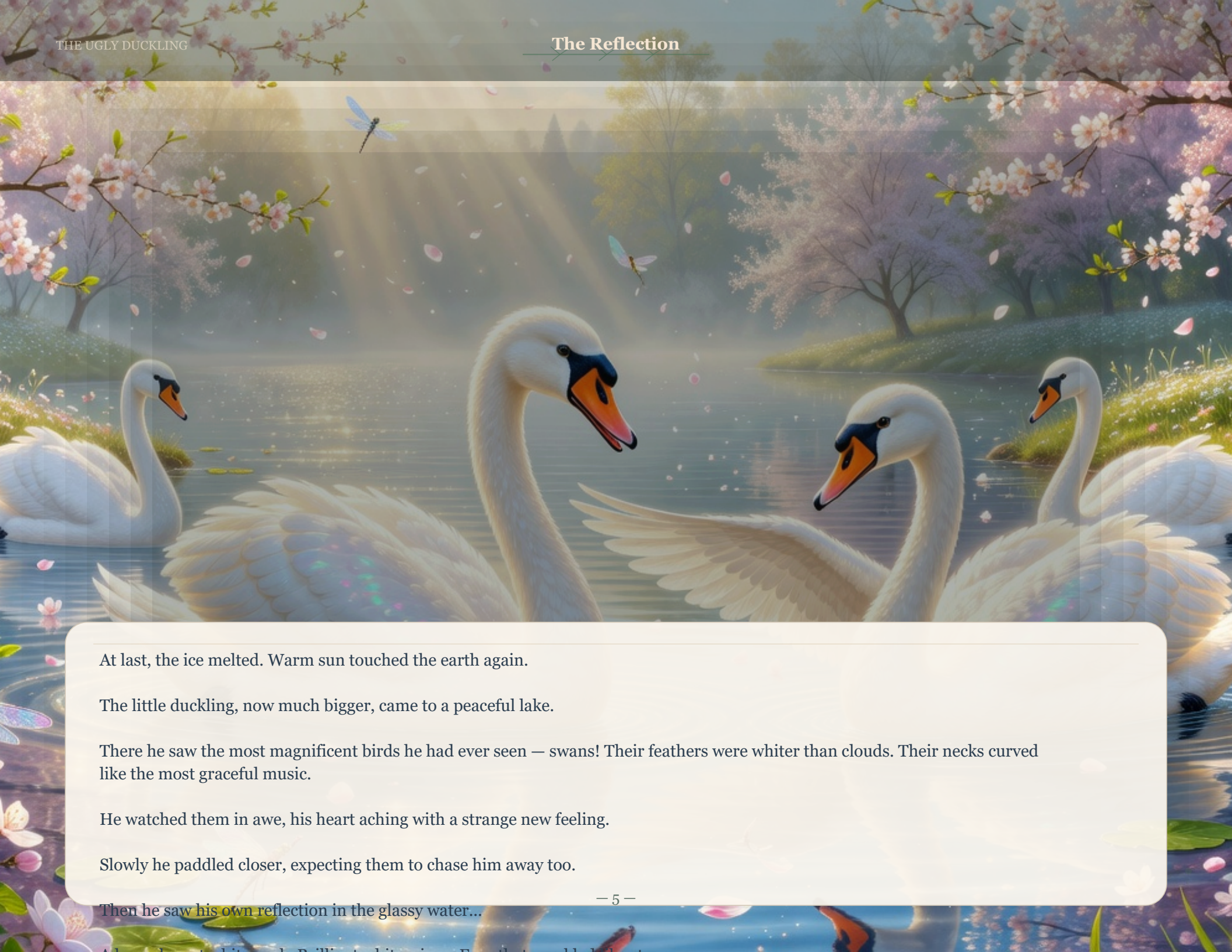
He walked through golden autumn fields, then into lonely marshes where wild ducks hissed, "Go away, ugly thing!"

Winter arrived with bitter winds. Snow covered everything.

Cold and hungry, the little duckling found shelter under an old wooden bridge.

He curled into a tiny ball, listening to the howling wind, and wondered if anyone in the whole wide world would ever be kind to him.





At last, the ice melted. Warm sun touched the earth again.

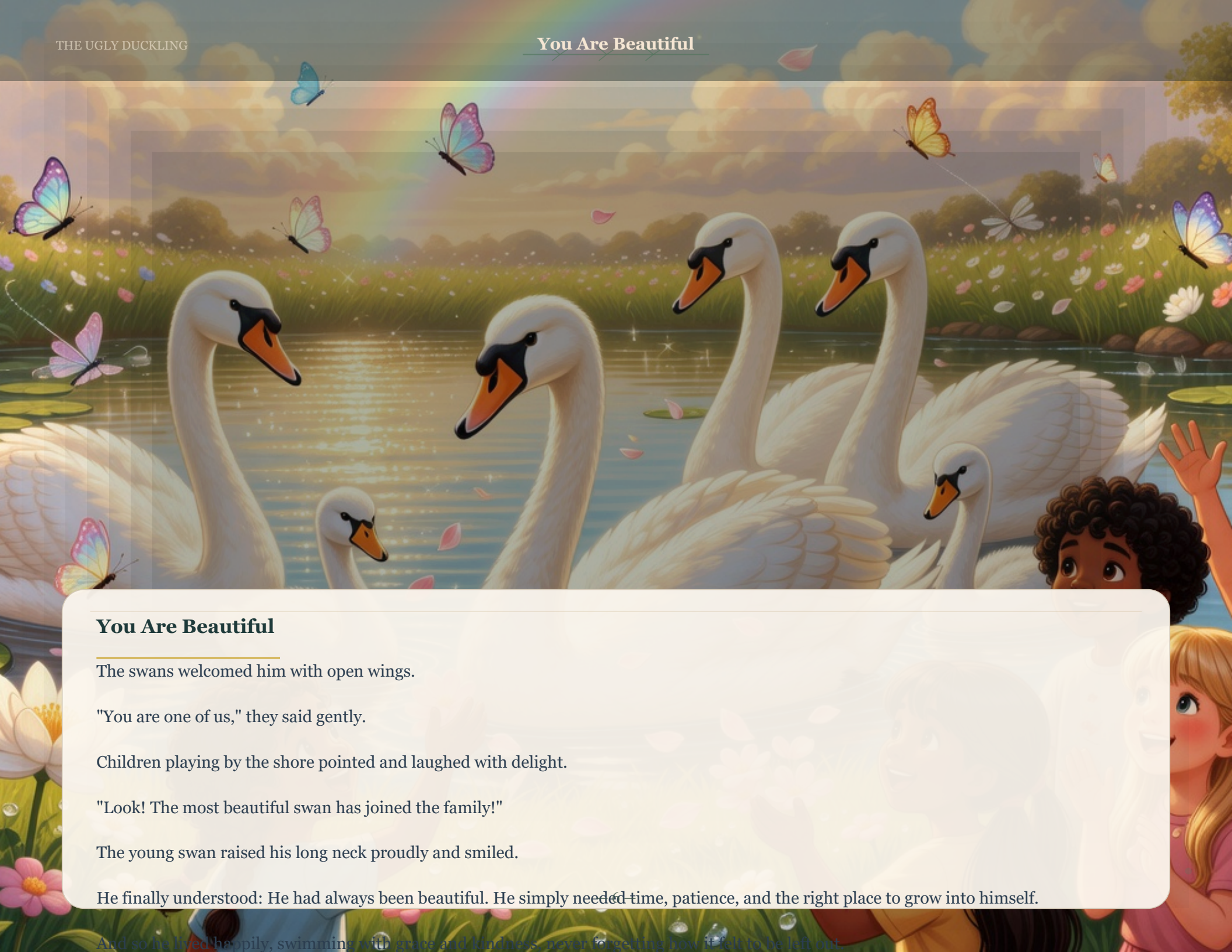
The little duckling, now much bigger, came to a peaceful lake.

There he saw the most magnificent birds he had ever seen — swans! Their feathers were whiter than clouds. Their necks curved like the most graceful music.

He watched them in awe, his heart aching with a strange new feeling.

Slowly he paddled closer, expecting them to chase him away too.

Then he saw his own reflection in the glassy water...



You Are Beautiful

The swans welcomed him with open wings.

"You are one of us," they said gently.

Children playing by the shore pointed and laughed with delight.

"Look! The most beautiful swan has joined the family!"

The young swan raised his long neck proudly and smiled.

He finally understood: He had always been beautiful. He simply needed time, patience, and the right place to grow into himself.

And so he lived happily, swimming with grace and kindness, never forgetting how it felt to be left out.